

Is Microsoft's Domination Really unjust?



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The last couple of years have witnessed the growth of Linux from an operating system that started out as the plaything of a small group of programmers to one that is taken seriously all over the world.

Linux is the best operating system around. Linux is proof of the power of communities. Linux stands for Freedom of choice. So claim its ardent supporters.

Unlike the Macintosh operating system, Linux doesn't face the challenge of convincing people to switch to a more expensive and proprietary hardware platform. Neither has it been stopped in its tracks by limited hardware support, as was the fate of BeOS. For Windows 98 users the differences in stability should itself have been sufficient reason to switch over. But even though Linux is virtually free, people haven't been convinced to make the shift.

So what is really holding up this operating system in its quest for popularity with regular desktop computer users?

The answer lies in the little details.

What is popularly referred to as the 'Linux Libraries Dependency Hell', makes installing new applications a tiresome process. Many popular Windows applications are still not available on Linux and the few world-class Linux applications have their own quirks. Consider GIMP, which could really challenge Photoshop if the interface wasn't so clumsy. Issues such as this make the transition to Linux extremely inconvenient for Windows users.

Newer distributions are as easy to install as Windows and the Linux user interface itself has made great progress over the last year. However, there's not much innovation directed at making it easier to use for people unfamiliar with computing. The developers have wasted several opportunities to prove that Linux is not just for geeks and they will now find it even more difficult to make progress against the latest Microsoft products. The traditional instability of the Windows desktop OSes has been largely eliminated in Windows XP.

If Linux is to become more popular, its applications need to compete with the best that Windows has to offer both in the features offered, and in usability. The only way to seriously challenge Windows is by concentrating on making Linux even more easy to use. This would go a long way in ensuring that Linux moves beyond being an operating system that so many love but very few choose actually to use.

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